A BRIDGE OF DESPAIR

The 143-year-old bridge over the river Machchhu was under repair and renovation for more than six months until it was reopened to the public only four days before the disaster. What lies behind the collapse of the bridge that was once considered an engineering marvel?

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS & TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**
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HISTORY

Inaugurated on February 20, 1879, by the then governor of Bombay Presidency, Sir Richard Temple, the Jhoolto Pul was built during the reign of Sir Waghji Thakor, then the ruler of the Morbi princely state, to connect Darbargadh Palace with Nazarbaug Palace across the river Machchhu

₹3.5 LAKH
Cost of construction

FIVE MAJOR LAPSES

1. The bridge was thrown open to the public sans a safety audit
2. There was no effort to control the footfall on the bridge
3. There is ambiguity about the scope of repairs. Police say material was added to the deck, making it heavier, but the rusty cables were not replaced
4. No one from the Morbi municipality has been held responsible
5. Opposition leaders are asking why the FIR doesn't name Oreva Group chairman Jaysukh Patel or top managers



THE STRUCTURE

Bridge type: **Suspension**

The deck is hung below suspension cables on vertical suspenders. The main cables connect the towers at either end of the bridge, and along with the vertical suspenders, bear the weight of the deck